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Ruth Brown

Versatility might be vocalist Ruth Brown's middle name. Born in Portsmouth, Virginia in 1928, she first gained public attention when Blanche Calloway brought her to New York in 1949. Since then Ruth has done it all, performing and recording R&B, Gospel and jazz both here and abroad. Her numerous recordings for Atlantic put her on the top of the R&B charts in the 1950s and her versatility allowed her to record with jazz groups such as The Thad Jones-Mel Lewis Orchestra. A recent inductee to the Rock & Roll Hall of Fame, Ruth currently resides in Las Vegas and can be heard at festivals across the country.

Ruth was interviewed in Scottsdale, Arizona on March 4, 1995 by Michael Woods.

MW: We are filming a jazz archive for Hamilton College, and we are very flattered and privileged to have Ruth Brown, one of the greatest rhythm & blues singers there has ever been, and we want to ask you some questions about your lifestyle and what was going on at the time that you started singing, and some of the other great artists that you've worked with, and what all this music means. Tell us in your definition what is rhythm & blues?

RB: Really basic. And in my day, really black is what it meant. But I'm entitled, or I think I find it necessary to say that that explanation is not necessarily the best one, because rhythm & blues has affected all cultures. It has crossed all lines. I'm amazed that even, now in the later years when we have the opportunity to travel outside the United States, which I didn't get that opportunity when I was young and physically able to handle it, but now that we do, when we go out of the country I usually am concerned that because of the language barrier, and not being able to speak the language, that there would be some problem with presenting the music. And so far, that has not been a problem, because this music jumps every barrier that there is. Because it is basically rhythm. It is basically simple melody. It is basically a music that we can duplicate almost to the letter, even these many years afterwards, because when it was done in the beginning it was not over - amplified. It was not done in an entertainer's, or engineer's booth, if I must say. Not a lot of overdubbing, not a lot of reverbs, and that kind of thing, so consequently when you make a personal appearance, if you have a good six-piece band, you can make this music sound almost the way it did. Of course now we have to sort of change the tempo, cause the new generation don't want to jag the way we did. So the tempos have been upped a little bit. But —

MW: Tell me about some of those slower tempos. What else was going on, why they wanted those slower tempos.

RB: Oh we called it if you will excuse the expression, "coffee grinding music."

MW: Okay.

RB: I knew that's what you wanted me to say, because that's what it was. You know we called it "coffee grinding music," and I'm very proud to say that I sang some of that and saw a lot of that going on. We said "coffee grinding" because it was such a personal kind of an attitude that it wanted and required and made you want to hold somebody really close to you. You know you could really hold on to somebody and relate to what was being played or sung by the artist, and as I always say in my act, you just got yourself a dark spot and held on and moved from the waist down. That's why it's lasting. Because it spoke of love, and love is continuous.

MW: You say though that this music, my thoughts of early rhythm & blues was that this music had something incredibly alive in it, because it was basically being sung and performed by black performers for predominantly black audiences.

RB: Yes.

MW: So there was a communal effect there. Could you talk about that communal effect?

RB: Yes.

MW: Could you talk about the music also being need-based?

RB: Yeah, well the reason that what you say is very true is because at that time, when I first began recording, which was in 1948, the music that I sang or that other artists like myself, — Jackie Wilson, The Drifters, The Clovers, The Flamingos, Chuck Willis, Roy Brown, Charles Brown, Wynonie Harris, to name only a few — was referred to as race music. And it was not played by your top 100 stations. Basically, every southern town had a local radio station. The wattage wasn't so powerful that you could hear what they played up north so to speak, but there was one station that was very responsible for this music being heard as far east and west as it was. And that was small radio station in Gallatin, Tennessee called Randy's Record Shop. Now what was unknown to the listening public was that the disc jockey at that station was a country & western person. He was white, he was not black. But he had the love for this music. He had the most popular radio station that there was. It was called Randy's Record Shop. And that is how the voice of Ruth Brown got to be heard as far as California, as far as Chicago, you know, all the midwest, even though I was basically located in Virginia, which was my state of origin.

MW: Something I wanted to ask you is this. These records were not always nationally distributed either, where there was what they call Mom and Pop record stores.

RB: Yes indeed.

MW: Tell us about that.

RB: You could buy them locally in your neighborhood and they would probably order a hundred maybe from the record companies and get rid of that hundred at one time, and

then order more. And you must remember now, in those days we had the huge 78s, breakable, and a lot of times, from the artists' point of view, you were told that so many promotional records were broken in distribution or in the mails, and so consequently by the time you got your royalty statement that was written off as a loss, you know, as in those days most everything we did was written up on the royalty statement. That is the reason we are fighting even now for royalties. Because in the days that I was recording we were charged for everything: studio time, musicians, manuscripts, promotional copies, distribution, everything. If they sent out and brought some sandwiches in for lunch it was on my bill, you know. But the music transcended all of that and as I say, it was very personal in that we had to go to the people to present this music. And when I say go to the people, I mean go wherever there was a place that enabled them to dance. Most times it would be a barn or a warehouse, and in the warehouse, depending on what time of the season we went, if it was cotton time, the cotton was still packed up on one side. If they had been harvesting tobacco, tobacco was stacked up on one side. And if it was cold weather, a lot of times there was a barrel, a big oil drum in the center of the floor with a flame burning. People would dance and then go over and warm your hands and go back and dance some more. Most times the stages were not what you see now, they were most times flatbed trucks that had been rolled together and put some bricks under the wheels to keep them from rolling, and that was your stage, that's where you performed.

MW: How did you when you traveled from town to town, how did you deal with the hotels or lack of hotels?

RB: There were none most times. Lack of hotels is what it was. What you had to do was, you always left in time to get into the city where you were going to work and get there early enough to go down on what we call the "main drag." You know you'd get in town and not know just where to go, and when you'd ask instructions usually they would say to you, "Find the railroad track, and once you find the railroad track, cross over." You understand, once you get on the other side of the track, that's where you're going to be performing in that immediate area. So what you did was get down to the main street, go to the local restaurant, the fellas would find the local barber shops, at that time they were having the doos, you know, with the doo-rags you had to find somebody to comb that. But you would get into that neighborhood and inquire of somebody, most times, who had a house and some extra room. There were a lot of what you call "tourist homes" you know what I'm saying? And you'd go and get a room there. And I can remember many times and I've gone in and people have like doubled their children up and took the children, the room the children were sleeping in to give to me and my assistant or something, and members of the band. Usually if there was a restaurant, upstairs

somewhere they would have some room, and that's where we would stay. I mean we did not have the opportunity to visit the Holiday Inns, believe me. That was not possible.

MW: One other thing I wanted to ask you, you know, talk to us about how the music made the difference. You say when they used to have the dances there they'd like have a rope, and the whites would be on one side and the blacks would be on the other. And tell us how the music made the difference.

RB: Well most times, as I said, we worked warehouses and barns, and nine times out of ten that didn't have what you call the "second balcony." If we were lucky to play a county hall or an auditorium sometimes, they had a balcony, and in that balcony was called the spectators. These were the whites who bought tickets to come in to hear the music but were not allowed to come on the dance floor. Sometimes it was vice versa. The whites would be down and the blacks would be up in the balcony and not allowed to come down. But in places such as barns, warehouses, where there was just one level, they would separate the races with a rope, and I say, a clothesline was what it was, an oversized clothesline. And most times someone had taken a huge cardboard and written "colored" which was the definition of our ethnic group at that particular time, and on the other side the card would say "white." And the white spectators were allowed to dance on that side of the rope, and the black on this side. But what they did not anticipate was that the music generated such a joy, people got to dancing, the ropes would fall down, I seen it happen many times. And people would continue to dance, and just wander in to each other's space. Nobody would say a thing for a moment, and then it would occur to some official that, uh oh, the rope is down and they're dancing in the same space, and we can't have that. And then somebody would run up on the stage and say, "Stop the music" you know and they'd just stop the music and go back and put the rope in place, and you had to go back on your given side.

MW: And the music was really trying to send a message wasn't it?

RB: And the music was, at that time. You see people had control over where you could go, where you could sit, but the one thing about that music was that it was the radio, the disc jockeys who played that music who were responsible for the music becoming what it was. And parents, unlike today with television I think and changed channels, they had no control over the radio dial, you see? And I've had many kids come to me and say they had to hide their radio, put the pillow over it, anything so the parents wouldn't know what was playing. But they could turn that dial and hear what was being done, and enjoyed it. And having to listen to a radio DJ, now unlike seeing everything visual on television, you had to use your imagination a little bit. And we had disc jockeys that were just funny, clean, funny and creative. They all had a character of their own, you know they had a slang talk, a way of speaking that, even myself in the beginning I'd get up and as soon as

my daddy was out the house and I could see him going to work, I would switch the dial to a radio station that played a program "The Mail Bag." My daddy didn't want us to hear it in the house. But as soon as he was out, you know, that's where we would turn it, to "The Mail Bag." So radio was very very important in that particular time. The DJs, you'd get into town and you'd have to go in to these radio stations and talk, and a lot of times people would not buy tickets because you bought tickets at the door. There was not all that much advanced sale. What was done in advance was when the posters went up that you were coming into town. Those posters usually went up at least a month before you got there.

MW: And that was done by a guy called a "front man?"

RB: You know it. The "front man" is exactly right. And people would begin at that time to decide what they're going to wear to the dance as this was a special occasion. They'd start getting their outfits together. But you had to get in town and show yourself before they'd buy those tickets. Because people worked hard, a lot of times people were sharecropping and I've worked dances where they came in and signed a book, they didn't have to buy the ticket. And a lot of times the landholder that they were working for was the one who was promoting the dance, you know? And they would come and sign that book and at the end of the week or whatever when they got paid, that was deducted.

MW: I wanted to ask you something about this. You know you said the people really worked hard. And here's one thing I thought about rhythm & blues. You know my father worked for a factory, Goodyear Tire & Rubber for 26 years. And when they work that hard, and they were able to save a little bit of money to have some fun on Saturday night, whoever the artist was that they were going to see, that artist had to make them feel like going back to work on Monday. Am I right?

RB: You better believe it. Consequently Louis Jordan came up with tune called "Saturday Night Fish Fry" which was in reality what happened on Saturday night. And when they came out to the dances, as I said, it was something that they prepared for a long time before that. And what they did, not only did they dress up to come to those dances, but they also brought little boxes with food, you know, a little beverage wrapped in aluminum foil that they hid under the table, and some good fried chicken and some nice biscuits and some pies. All of that came to the dances. And it became sort of personalized because I've had many people say to me, "Uh, Miss Brown," they got to the place where they could call you Ruth and that was fine, "come to our table when you get through." And we did that so often, you know, it was really, really kind of personal at that time.

MW: So in other words, you're saying that the music was powerful in the fact that the artist was on the same plane with his audience. None of this superstar stuff like —

RB: Thank you, yes.

MW: The star pulls up in a Ferrari.

RB: You could touch them. They were reachable. They were reachable. Most times we toured in buses, station wagons. And they when you got so-called to the top of the ladder which eventually happened in my case, there were those stars who did have the Cadillacs and whatnot, but you took it on your own, you chanced it, to go to the deep south with that kind of a vehicle. And I got arrested a couple of times. They locked the car up a couple of times, and they want to know how you could afford that even though — I had an experience and when my book comes out it will speak of an occasion in which we were going to Gulfport, Mississippi — Charles Brown, and Paul "Hucklebuck" Williams and myself. And the police stopped us and said that we were doing like 30 miles per hour in a 25 mile zone, something like that. And made us all get out of our cars and of course these were all nice cars, a couple of Chryslers and things remind me right. Anyway what we eventually had to do was when we pulled out all the instruments, to prove that they weren't stolen, we had to do a concert on the side of the road which was probably the most embarrassing thing that's ever happened to me. I saw that in a movie recently—

MW: "The Five Heartbeats?"

RB: Yes. I don't know if it happened to them but it happened to me. It did. And I was the only one standing there not doing anything. And my pianist named Lee Anderson, who now is still alive in Seattle. I saw him a couple of years ago and we remembered that all of the musicians had taken out their instruments and were playing, you know, on the side of the road. And this tall policeman says to Lee Anderson, "Well what are you playing?" And he said, "I play piano." And he said, "Well why are you not playing?" No piano, you know? And in those days, we weren't carrying electric pianos like they do now, they carry the keyboards and whatnot, you know. And so the officer said, "Well you got five seconds to start playing something."

MW: Oh, that's sad.

RB: The funniest thing happened. Intuitiveness. When it's about survival you think of something. I'll never forget the band was playing and he leaned over the hood of the car and started playing on the hood of the car. And the police officers accepted that. He proved that he knew how to move his hands at least. And then last but not least, they looked at me and I would be standing there very arrogant in those days. I didn't fear death, you understand? And they said, "And who are you?" And I was very vain and I said, "I'm the person who pays all of these musicians" you know. I ended up singing on the side of the road. You know, he brandished his pistol and put his hand on it, and said, "Well let me hear you sing something." And so there we were, all seven of us, standing on the side of the road as the cars were going by and going around or slowing down, doing this performance.

MW: You know there's a classic case of the police harassing Miles Davis 'cause he had his beautiful Ferrari, and he finally got this license plate that says "I own it."

RB: I own it, yes. Well those things occurred quite often. I had fire set to my car in Birmingham, you know. We've had occasions to be stopped and taken to what we call "night court" where the judge lived back in the woods somewhere, you didn't go to the station you went to his house. And they tell you that you owed two hundred, three hundred dollars, and they wanted it right then and we had to pay it and all this, to move, you know. Those are some of the reasons that caused me to be a little vain and arrogant and adamant about this music surviving because the people who performed it paid a price for it, you know.

MW: Yes. And I try to share that. I teach History of Jazz class and I try to share those things. I want to ask you something now about rhythm & blues as compared to Gospel. People say it's the same chords. It's the same beat. One person said it's like the only difference is one guy's talking about God and one guy's talking about his girlfriend.

RB: There you go, it's just changing the words.

MW: Give us an example of a couple that were close.

RB: You know what you say is very true and I find myself having to watch that when you do Gospel, and especially the now generation Gospel. I have to really closely listen to what's being said, you know, to kind of slow down and respect the fact that they're singing Gospel. Unlike when I came along, my father was Baptist, was Methodist. My mother was Baptist. So I was christened as a Methodist as a baby, and I sang in that choir when I became of age. But each summer when I had to work in the fields in cotton and tobacco, I was sent to North Carolina. My mother's people were Baptist. My grandmother refused to accept the fact that by having a few speckles of water dropped on my head that that meant anything spiritually. And so consequently we were required to go to the moaner's bench. The moaner's bench. You had to sit there. The whole month of August was the viable month. So you went to church in the morning, if you were a sinner as the deacons called you, you sat on that moaner's bench while the older deacons walked around you and admonished you for not having received God, you see? And if and when you did you stood up and shouted. And of course we sat there so long that my sisters and I decided we were just going to hop up. We had just rehearsed our chorus before we left the house one day, we were tired of sitting there. So we hopped up at a given moment, like the Rockettes, we'd be with legs hopping and everything. Of course my grandmother had a very keen eye. And she saw all of this. And she just gave us one look, you know in those days all they had to do was give you a look, and didn't have to say anything —

MW: And just peak over the glasses.

RB: That's right. Oh, you play with God, will ya? And by the time she got through admonishing us, I said all that to say that there is this fine line and it had to do with the lyrics. Of course there's a song that we do even now, "You're the Best Thing That's Ever Happened to Me." In the church we say God is the best thing that's ever happened to me. I did a song once called "I Can See Everybody's Baby but I Can't See Mine." The Dixie Hummingbirds did it and it was called "I Can See Everybody's Mother but I Don't See Mine." You see, it's just about the lyrics. That's all it is. And even now I can take any song and change one line, change one word, replace "love" or "darling" with "God." Or "Our Father" and slow the tempo, lay it back, lay the tempo back, and it becomes Gospel spiritual.

MW: You know there's a, there's a rendition of I think BeBe and CeCe [Winans] doing "Lord Lift Us Up Where We Belong" which was song a song from a movie.

RB: That's right. "Lord Lift Us Up Where We Belong," and it makes sense, wouldn't it? That was from "An Officer and a Gentleman" the song, it really was. Well as I said, it's just the attitude that can change it. I mean like even coming up to sing Gospel and there's a beat behind it. I made this statement that my mother used to say, "If it moves your hip and not your soul, be careful," you know but you've really got to watch it nowadays, cause you'll find without thinking you will move your hips to the music. I don't think that God cares.

MW: Well let me ask you this. Now they had a little thing that they came up with, the sanctified church. And you know how when the music gets going or the sermon's good or the choir just got done singing a good number and the folk get to dancing. And now but they said it wasn't dancing as long as you didn't cross your feet.

RB: Don't' cross your legs.

MW: As long as you didn't pick that one foot up over the other and cross it, then they wouldn't —

RB: Right, and it says, make the joyful noise unto the Lord. The many times that I used to play the Apollo Theater, the most urgent thing that would happen when the show was over, everybody would come out the stage entrance which was on 126th Street, come around the block to 8th Avenue, past the Braddock Bar and cross the street. On the corner at 125th and 8th, upstairs, was Daddy Grace's church. And the windows were always open. Now they had saxophone, drum, trombone, guitar, tambourine. If you wanted to hear music, people dancing in the streets down underneath.

MW: And the tambourines with their heads on them right?

RB: Thank you, well, not that little ring. See when I did a tune in 1953 called "Mama He Treats Your Daughter Mean," I played the tambourine with the head. I notice everybody now, but that tune, the introduction was four bars for nothing [taps] that's the original

entrance. But all the tambourines they use now they take the head off, put their hands through it, it rings, and it's simpler. But that tambourine came out of the church and it still does now. You know if you want to hear the greatest, the greatest, what I say the greatest soul searching music, you go to the holiness church, the Pentecostal, you know, that's where it is. They truly make a joyful noise unto the Lord. And most of your great R&B singers came out of that kind of setting.

MW: You know I want to ask you a question here. As we can kind of try to relate this to jazz, you say the music was expensive because it cost you something. And I was thinking there seems to be a spiritual aspect, even to the jazz, even, but a lot of preachers said, oh, that's the devil's music. But at the same time many of those were the backup musicians for the R&B groups.

RB: Of course. John Coltrane was in my band. We went through the south. John Coltrane was in my band, he was in Paul "Hucklebuck" Williams, who had the big record "The Hucklebuck" before Chubby Checker got it and called it "The Twist." John Coltrane was in that band. I toured all through the south with Johnny Hodges, Richard oh, God he was killed in the car with Clifford Brown —

MW: Richard Powell.

RB: Richard Powell was my pianist. You see, Bud Powell's brother. He was my pianist, you know? And I'm saying Kenny Burrell, all of them at one time or the other played that music, because that's the basis of everything that they do. You know and if jazz indeed had its beginning in New Orleans, please, what was that, you know? The funerals? You've got to see that, have you ever seen one in New Orleans? You know what that's like. If you can stay still, I'll bet you, you can't. But that's like the old people used to say you rejoice at the going out and you weep at the coming in. And that's what that music is about. But there is a very fine line. I always said that I would suppose that truly the difference between the real jazz musicians and the Gospel or rhythm & blues artists is that the technique, the improvisation, they had to know a little something about the written note, I would think. Because there were a few that I knew who had no knowledge of it. Wes Montgomery.

MW: Wes Montgomery could not read.

RB: Could not read.

MW: But he had a good ear though.

RB: A great ear. And I think that that's — Dizzy Gillespie told me that once when I got a chance to go to Japan the very first time. I went to Japan with Dizzy Gillespie and the Modern Jazz Quartet, and Sonny Stitt. And I was just so apprehensive because we were going to play the Budokan, and here I was this rhythm & blues artist, you know. And Dizzy said, "If you can hear it, you can sing it." And I could always hear it. I don't read

either, don't read a note, you know, but always there are a lot of pictures of me looking at the music. It looks good. It gives me status, you know. Especially when I went to go into the studios with the likes of your Arnett Cobbs and your Count Basies and your Billy Eckstines, and I got to be on tour with these great people. Whenever there was an opportunity to pose with them, there is always a piece of music, you know. It may look as though I knew, but no, that's, it's really not necessary, especially like the music I'm proud to be a part of, it came from inside.

MW: Have you worked with Count Basie?

RB: Oh, I did.

MW: And tell us about the sound of that band, and how that worked in with the rhythm & blues kind of sound that you brought in your voice.

RB: Well I think when everybody — I worked with Basie, of course. I toured with Count Basie, George Shearing, Billy Eckstine as a unit. I think that the Basie band was probably, of course it ended up being probably the most respected along with the Ellington, and Jimmy Lunceford orchestra. In those days we had dance bands, you see? In Raleigh-Durham, North Carolina they had what was called the "June German." I don't know if you're familiar with that but if you ever do research on it, it was five days of dancing. It was called the "June German." People traveled from everywhere to come there for that. Now during those five days, you would find the likes of Buddy Johnson, a great dance band, Earl Hines, Jimmy Lunceford, Erskine Hawkins, Lucky Millinder, and Count Basie of course. Ellington on occasion. But for the dance marathons, and that's what they were, these were the chosen dance bands. Now the Basie band was the one band that rhythmatically you could not beat that, you know it was just there. The secret of that, you know was Freddie Green. People don't talk about that, but that was the secret of the Basie band.

MW: Well you know other artists have come in here and we've talked about the Basie band and they've said those exact words.

RB: Of course.

MW: Like they read it off a script.

RB: Of course. It's there. And he set beside Basie over 40 years. When Basie passed, he didn't live long after that.

MW: That was his life.

RB: Freddie Green, that was his life. I saw him, he said, "Well Basie's gone I don't know what I'm gonna do." And sure enough. But he sat there for over 40 years playing that [scats] that was the Basie band, you see? The simpler, the better. The simpler, the better. And of course Basie, he was such a wonderful individual. You know and I think the thing about those days that was really great was there was no competitiveness. Whatever was

good for the show, that's what we did. We toured together, we rode the buses together, we lived under the same circumstances, we ate under the same circumstances, and when you went to the stage at night, it was a combined effort, you know? It wasn't about who can outdo the other. It's like here, we're here as a unit, let's make those people who bought the tickets glad they came, and let's have them ask when we will be back again, you know. I think that was the thing that I remember most about it, you know. And I worked with Basie many, many times.

MW: Have you had an opportunity to either sing on the same program with or privy to the personal sounds of Joe Williams?

RB: Well of course. Joe was in the band when we was touring together. And of course we now live in the same town, in Vegas. Joe's been living there quite a while. In fact the last time I saw him we did the tribute for Peggy Lee. And Joe, again, is like what I call the master blues singer. He is the master. The most, not predictable, but really predictable. You almost know where he's going musically you know. And I think one of the greater voices that I've ever heard is Joe Williams. And he still remains that way. Very proud to that effect. He doesn't — how should I say — he has not prostituted that particular sound that he has, that style that he has. He's just true blues singer. "Every Day I Have the Blues" is his. Who else does it, you know what I'm saying? And, "Going to Chicago sorry I can't take you" — you understand — "Ain't nothin' in Chicago that a monkey person can do." That belongs to Joe Williams. Yes, I know him very well and proud to say I know him.

MW: A couple of other things I'd like to ask you. If you had some words to the wise, to say to young jazz singers coming up, about the real essence of the music, what would you share?

RB: Well, as I said before, I'm not a technical musician as far as the written note is concerned. But what I have aspired to do, now that I'm being accepted in that gender as a jazz singer in some places, is to first of all as a vocalist, pay attention to what comes out of your mouth, what you are saying, the written word. You know as I say, technically, a lot of people who can read music can just pick up a lead sheet and sing the song. But your job is to make that song apply to someone. Try to be as true to the melody as you can. One of the things over the years I learned in listening to all the great singers, there are a lot of them that I've attempted to emulate, but there's one that I am not stupid enough to try, and that's Ella Fitzgerald. The lady is without a doubt the greatest that I ever heard, technically. The one thing I never tried to do is scat sing. Even though Ella told me she started that way. She was singing, and forgot the lyric one day, and couldn't think of anything else to do. So she started to scat. But all the great singers, like Carmen McRae, Sarah Vaughan, my friend Dinah Washington, all of these ladies, Aretha even now, all

played piano. They were musicians. I couldn't do that. So I had to pay attention to the word and the melody. And I find that to be a source of being able to handle the song. To me if I pay attention to what's coming out at this point I just attempt to make a person listen to what I'm saying. To make it believable, you know. To have someone come up and say, "You know I've heard that song done a lot of times but when you sang it I really felt it," you know. I think that is the payback for that. A lot of times I have a respect for every music. I can find something in all of it. But there have been some occasions that it gets a little abstract, if I can't hear the melody, if I can't hear the, feel the beat, you know? I think that comes from the R&B training that you feel the beat. It's always there. It's always there. And when I lose that sometime I kinda, I couldn't say that I would stand up and be able to sing with Ornette Coleman, you know, I respect him, but I don't think that I could vocalize. And there is that difference you know. There are a lot of wonderful musicians who are fantastically good in what they do, but very few have a knack for accompanying a singer. There is a difference in accompanying a singer. To give her room, space, for what it is—

MW: And yet support.

RB: And yet support. And you can't always find that.

MW: It's a special skill, isn't it.

RB: That's it. It's a special skill.

MW: Now you tell me am I wrong where I've found the greatest accompanist for singers is in the black church.

RB: Oh why of course. Of course. Because we're not in a hurry. And that's what I tell everybody. Where you going? Take your time. Slow down. Listen to what you're saying. Not only should it feed off and affect somebody else, it should feed back on you. It's like looking in the mirror, you know? You used to always look in the mirror when you talk to yourself, because it's going to feed back on you. You see and you will feel it. Same way with your music. If you sing it, and it's heartfelt, you'll get that too. I've been on stage sometime and some nights are different than others. You know you can focus on someone in your audience and get really locked into them, you know you get eye contact and you realize that they're really listening to what you're singing. And before you know it, you're hearing yourself. As I've said in my, I call it my older days, in my twilight years I've started to collect and listen to some of my recordings. I never did listen to my own stuff that much. But I started to listen to some of it now. Some of it's pretty good. But some of it is awful. You know.

MW: Tell us one of the ones that's pretty good. Tell us one of the ones that you think is classic.

RB: I did an album in 1965 called "Ruth Brown '65" on Mainstream. The company went out of business. The record has been re-issued this year on SONY under a new name, it's

now called “Softly.” And in that album I did “Here’s That Rainy Day,” I did “Why Do You Whisper Green Grass” which was an old Bill Kenny tune from the Inkspots, you know which dates back to my youth. And in that I also did “Porgy” — “I Love You Porgy.” Things that I had forgotten that I’d ever touched on. And I was listening to that album and I said, [whistles] I didn’t sound bad, you know? And then you go back and get some things like “Lucky Lips” and “This Little Girl’s Gone Rockin’” and “I Wrote My Momma a Letter When I Had Long Silky Curls” and right now it sounds kind of ridiculous. They say, “Would you sing that song?” Are you kidding? I don’t know what made me sing it then, you know? But it does make a difference.

MW: One last thing I would like to ask you. Who is coming up on the scene now as young R&B artists, that you think has their thumb on the pulse of great traditions.

RB: Well I’ll tell you there’s a fine line now. A lot of the people that are being categorized as R&B singers, I don’t know. The category is strange and different now, you know? But I tell you, I admire Oleta Adams, wherever she’s been, I like her. I’ve heard some things by Toni Braxton, I like her a little bit. And I always slide back into Aretha on some things she just refuses to go away I say. When she’s right she’s just right. But there are a lot of the new artists that I’m not familiar with. I could talk to my daughter about that and she brings me up to what’s going on in the new voices. And there are those that I hear and can’t identify by name, you know. The music is still good. There are some things that don’t touch me but fortunately you can always turn the dial, you can take the compact disc out, you don’t have to be required to listen to it. I like groups like Take 6, I love them very much. And I like some of the things that BeBe and CeCe Winans are doing. I don’t know who else I can really touch on right now. I like Luther Ingram, is that his name? Luther Ingram?

MW: Luther Vandross?

RB: Not Luther Vandross, I know Luther Vandross.

MW: James Ingram?

RB: James Ingram.

MW: I went to high school with James.

RB: You did? Yes. I like him. Of course now I listen to him and all you got to do is turn on Michael Bolton and you’ll hear all of his style. Michael Bolton’s doing it, thank you. But nonetheless, there are a lot of artists that I feel I maintain a lot of respect for. I like Luther Vandross also, you know, but I think if I had a preference I like James Ingram.

MW: I’ll get word to James on that. He’ll appreciate and be flattered by that.

RB: Would you do that? Okay. Thank you very much.

MW: Well we're going to conclude this portion of our interview right now. We've been very flattered to get some incredible information from Ruth Brown, and we hope to continue this and build this archive over several years at Hamilton College. It has been an honor.

RB: The privilege has been mine. Thank you.